

There are 15 research and development corporations (RDCs). These RDCs are a key pillar of Australia's agricultural research and innovation system. RDCs are jointly funded by the Australian Government and the agriculture, fisheries and forestry industries. This funding is invested in research and development, which includes extension, to drive the profitability, productivity and sustainability of the sector.

The RDC model is a government-industry partnership. It has contributed to innovation in the agricultural, fisheries and forestry sector for more than 35 years.

Funding

The RDCs are primarily funded through the research and development component of levies and charges. These levies and charges are imposed on agricultural, fisheries and forestry products through the [agricultural levy system](#).

RDCs invest in research and development programs to achieve industry outcomes and report to stakeholders on the outcomes delivered. To promote industry investment, the Australian Government generally matches 50% of expenditure on eligible research and development activities up to a legislated limit. For details on how matching funding works please refer to the Primary Industries Levies and Charges Disbursement Act 2024 (Disbursement Act).

Some RDCs have additional responsibilities, including marketing, commercial services and regulatory responsibilities. Marketing activities are also funded through industry levies. Commercial and regulatory services are funded through fees and charges.

RDCs may also receive additional funding from grants, industry and third parties to support their work. RDCs are accountable to both industry and government.

To learn more about the agricultural levy system visit the [about the levy system page](#).

Types of RDCs

There are 15 RDCs:

- 5 Commonwealth statutory bodies
- 10 industry-owned RDCs.

Commonwealth statutory RDCs are Australian Government entities with a board of directors appointed by the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry based on recommendations from a selection committee. They are recipient bodies under the agricultural levies legislation.

Commonwealth statutory RDCs, relevant legislation and declared representative organisation(s) are listed in this table:

If you have difficulty accessing these files, [contact us](#) for help.

Industry-owned RDCs are independent corporate entities registered under the Corporations Act 2001 and have expertise-based boards. They are declared as recipient bodies under the agricultural levies legislation.

If you have difficulty accessing these files, [contact us](#) for help.

The key performance and accountability framework for RDCs is set out in the statutory funding agreement between each RDC and the Commonwealth.

The statutory funding agreements include requirements for performance and transparency. They also include requirements for accountability to levy payers, the government and the public. The current funding agreements are valid from 2025-34 and are published on each RDC's website.

There are 5 performance principles within the funding agreements. These are intended to ensure RDCs spend levy funds and public money appropriately and focus on delivering research and development (and marketing) outcomes for their stakeholders.

The 5 performance principles are:

- Stakeholder engagement – Engage stakeholders to identify research and development activities and associated priorities that provide benefits to portfolio industries.
- Research and development activities and marketing activities – Ensure research and development activities, marketing activities and associated priorities are strategic, collaborative, and targeted to improve profitability, productivity, competitiveness, and preparedness for future opportunities/challenges through a balanced portfolio.
- Collaboration – Undertake strategic and sustained cross-industry and cross-sectoral collaboration that addresses shared challenges and draws on experience from other sectors.
- Governance – Ensure governance arrangements and practices fulfil legislative requirements and align with contemporary Australian best practice for open, transparent, and proper use and management of funds.
- Monitoring and evaluation – Demonstrate positive outcomes and delivery of research and development activities and marketing activities and associated benefits to levy and charge payers and the Australian community in general, and continuous improvement in governance and administrative efficiency.

The statutory funding agreements place restrictions on the RDCs from engaging in or funding agri-political activity.

In 2021, the government developed guidance to support the work undertaken by RDCs:

- The Guidelines for Statutory Funding Agreements outlines key performance indicators for each of the five performance principles outlined above.
- The Best Practice Guide to Stakeholder Consultation provides a set of guiding principles which apply to all RDCs and specific guidance for each individual RDC.

- The RDC Knowledge Transfer and Commercialisation Guide provides guidance for the management of technology commercialisation to assist driving commercialisation out of the RDCs and bring in extra funding from private sources.

Legislation, regulations and individual statutory funding agreements provide the framework for how RDCs operate.

The Primary Industries Research and Development Act 1989 (PIRD Act) and the Wine Australia Act 2013 (Wine Australia Act) set out arrangements for the establishment of the statutory RDCs. They also outline the functions of these RDCs and provide for certain governance arrangements.

The two Acts require the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry to declare at least one representative organisation for each statutory RDC. Declared industry representative organisations are listed in [Statutory RDCs](#).

The Disbursement Act provides for the disbursement of levy and matching payments to RDCs. It also provides for spending requirements in relation to these payments.

Statutory RDCs are also required to comply with the Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013.

These Acts, along with the funding agreements, set out obligations for statutory RDCs related to:

- finance
- performance
- reporting
- accountability
- industry consultation.

Industry-owned RDCs are declared by the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry as recipient bodies under the Disbursement Act. They are established under, and must comply with, the provisions of the Corporations Act 2001 where relevant. This Act sets out the obligations of companies and their boards of directors.

The Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry is responsible for administering the PIRD Act, Wine Australia Act and Disbursement Act relating to RDCs and has delegated some tasks to the department.

We can assist RDCs to understand their legislated obligations and statutory funding agreements. We also advise the minister on RDC-related matters. In doing so, we:

- administer the collection and disbursement of agricultural levies
- monitor the performance of RDCs through ongoing engagement including conducting annual performance meetings with each RDC
- request that each RDC arrange independent reviews of performance, no more than every 3 years, as required by funding agreements

- assist the minister to discharge statutory and parliamentary obligations, including providing advice on the operations of RDCs and their accountability of funds
- ensure the RDCs have a research and development (including extension) framework to underpin the profitability, productivity, competitiveness and long-term sustainability of portfolio industries.

We also engage strategically with the RDCs to foster collaboration, alignment and information sharing between government, RDCs and industry.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/innovation/research-development-corporations-companies>